

The Deceitfulness of Riches

We have been uncovering these five things the devil uses to hide behind, and we have been doing it out of the parable of the sower. I have been having the time of my life.

Passing in review, Mark 4:13 says:

Know ye not this parable?
and how then will ye know all parables?

In other words, if you do not understand how the Word is sown into your human spirit and produces up to a hundredfold, you have no basis to understand any other parable Jesus taught.

Then He gives the subject of the entire teaching:

The sower soweth the word.

Every parable has an objective. The subject is that the sower sows the Word. The objective is how to guard against these five things: persecutions, afflictions, cares of this life, deceitfulness of riches, and lusts of other things, and turn up to a hundredfold walk with God based on His Word.

As smart a strategist and military genius as the devil is, he is not going to come to you wearing horns and a tail. That would be stupid. Jesus already gave you power over all the power of the enemy. In a match of power, where you are actually using the power of God against him, the devil will avoid that confrontation with everything in him.

He does not want that kind of confrontation. That is why he has to deceive you into accepting your own defeat. Otherwise, he cannot defeat you.

The most popular thing he hides behind is religion. He loves to hide behind religion and whisper in your ear what God is, what God is not, what is God, and what is not. When he is done with you, you belong to a big denomination that after three generations has even removed salvation out of it.

"Let us just shake hands. We have a salvation-marching social club that does good works."

We are not excluding good works, but any organization that does good works and does not have the rebirth and the baptism of the Holy Spirit has already been deceived. Going to hell or not is not based on your good works. It is based on whether you are born again or not. A man can be born again, never do any good works, and go to heaven. It is not based on that.

The devil hides behind religion, and these five things he uses in our daily affairs: persecutions, afflictions, cares of this life, deceitfulness of riches, and lusts of other things.

Have you noticed what we have called the things he brings against us? We have called them everything but the devil. We have even blamed God for persecutions and afflictions, saying they came to teach us something.

"After all, Aunt Susie was a godly woman. If God was going to heal anybody, it would have been her, but she went ahead and died. So we know God does not heal all the time."

What are you going to do, change the Word of God?

Experience that is not worked by the Word is not worth two cents. Any experience you gain that you have worked from the Word of God is worth its weight in gold. But if your experiences are not based on the Word, they are not worth two cents.

Persecutions, afflictions, and cares are designed for one reason: to choke the Word or remove it from you before it has a chance to produce.

Let me give you some of God's wisdom. If you are working a job and want to enter the ministry, the stupidest thing you could do is quit the job.

What you need to do is sacrifice your time after the job. You want to pray four hours? Do it after you have worked. "I am going to quit and put God on the spot." Go right ahead. That does not mean you had any more faith before than after.

You want to produce faith? Go pray and meditate the Word after you have produced ten hours of work. If you really want to go full-time, force yourself to produce a thousand dollars more a month than you ever have before, and sow it into some old boy's ministry while you are praying four hours a day. Then you are getting in shape to handle some of the bills that will come your way.

In the last three weeks, we have had a ball studying persecutions, afflictions, and cares. Now we graduate to the fourth force the devil uses to neutralize and remove the Word of God out of us: the deceitfulness of riches.

The deceitfulness of riches is the man or woman being deceived by riches. That is a horrible thing.

Go to Luke 16:13:

No servant can serve two masters:
for either he will hate the one,
and love the other;
or else he will hold to the one,
and despise the other.
Ye cannot serve God and mammon.

Mammon breaks down to mean riches, especially riches pertaining to mankind and this temporary existence.

Notice the two masters Jesus lists. One is God. The other is mammon. He says you cannot serve both. You will hold to one and despise the other.

Is it not interesting that Jesus said the deceitfulness of riches entering in will choke the Word of God out of you, and when He Himself taught on money, He listed two masters people will serve: God on one hand, and mammon on the other.

The only protection a man has against the deceitfulness of riches is to develop exactly the opposite: a servant's heart.

I do not think there is any better way to reveal a servant's heart tonight than by giving you the same warning Jesus gave the Pharisees about the deceitfulness of riches. I explored the Word of God to find the heaviest teaching Jesus gave on it.

The reason we get deceived by riches is that we do not heed the warning of the power they carry. We keep thinking, "Not me, not me." Oh yes, you. After you understand the warning Jesus gives, you will understand my statement: the only protection against the deceitfulness of riches is a servant's heart.

Second to God alone, and in many people's lives not second but first, there is no other force on this side of eternity that carries the wallop that money carries. In the hands of a servant's heart, that wallop will be packed for the kingdom of God. In the hands of a man serving himself and the lusts of other things, it carries the same wallop, but it serves the wrong kingdom.

God has nothing against money. He is looking for servants He can put it in the hands of. He did not say money was the root of all evil. He said the love of it is.

A man deceived by riches will do anything for the love of money because it represents that powerful force second only to God. In fact, he is striving to replace God with it.

For many who know God, the power in money replaces God because it becomes their security. It sets itself up as what only God is supposed to be on the inside of His servants.

Many people have already switched their dependency from God onto the power that is in money. It is easy to do because money is the standard by which we govern the economy. It converts to food, clothes, or anything else we need. Pretty soon, it becomes easy to depend on the thing instead of the power that produced the thing.

The first thing God made known to my spirit through meditation was this: if I become an ultimate servant to God and God alone, then in proportion to how I serve the kingdom of God in prayer, giving, and faith directing the power in money, that is the proportion He will make money serve my ministry.

You cannot serve God and money. But to the proportion that you serve God, He will allow money to serve you.

If a person does not have it, it is because he does not have that kind of faith in God.

"I believe God will give me, give me, give me."

Yes, but how much do you believe God to give through you? Jesus said the measure you measure out will be measured back to you, good measure, pressed down, shaken together, and running over.

To the proportion you place your heart into His hands as a servant is the proportion He will allow you to serve.

When I become a servant to God and God alone, that is when He begins to allow me to be a steward. Money begins to serve the ministry.

We fail to heed the warning Jesus gave about the danger in the power of money. When He finished giving that warning, it made me sit up and take a whole different look than I had ever taken before.

God knows, and I know, that it is not my money He is after. It never has been and never will be. It is my faith. God wants my faith.

That is why He said:

Lay not up for yourselves treasures upon earth,
where moth and rust doth corrupt,
and where thieves break through and steal:
But lay up for yourselves treasures in heaven,
where neither moth nor rust doth corrupt,
and where thieves do not break through nor steal:
For where your treasure is,
there will your heart be also.

If your vision is so limited that the whole reason for your money and the power in it is to lay it up on this earth for super security, listen: God has nothing against you being secure. He does not care if you have two or three million dollars in the bank. The only thing He requires is that your faith be on deposit with Him.

You can say, "I could give that three million away in one minute." Could you?

People facing a deathbed, with cancer eating them from head to toe and three days to live, would have fed their three million into the gospel if they could start over. When it comes to eternal things and love, fruits of the Spirit and such, your dollar is not worth the paper it is printed on.

That person would beg God, "Give me another go-around. I know You told me to give it. I will do it now. Here is my faith."

He was not talking about throwing away every penny you have. He was talking about the leadership of the Spirit.

He said to lay up treasures in heaven because where your treasure is, there your heart will be also. It is not the dollar He is after. It never was. It is the placement of the faith in your heart.

If there is one place I want my heart to be, it is not misplaced in the temporary things the Gentiles seek. He says if you place your treasure into His kingdom, then you place your heart there. Your heart will not be misplaced in things the Gentiles seek after. It will be placed in His hands, and then He has the part of you that moves those things out. He has the part of you that faith generates through.

Let the trucks go on strike. Let them run out of oil so they cannot haul food into your major cities, where you are stacked up in little cardboard houses all in a row and your full source is the market down the street.

Do you know what kind of edge you are living on? There is no security outside God.

If I were some of you, I would practice fasting now. Do it when it carries gravity in the kingdom. I never did like enforced things anyway.

What will you do when the trucks strike, the money changes, and the bottom falls out of the market? Jump off a building in New York? The only reason you would is because your heart fell with it because it was placed in it.

When God has my treasure now, when I am the steward, when my own free moral agency makes the decision, when I lay it at His feet because it carries power for evangelism, then I deposit my treasure into heaven. My heart follows. It is not misplaced in the things the Gentiles seek after. God has that part of me that faith generates through.

He has me.

Then Matthew 6:22 takes place:

The light of the body is the eye:
if therefore thine eye be single,
thy whole body shall be full of light.

You know what these two physical organs are for. They let light into my body so I can walk by it.

The reason He wants your treasure is because He wants your spirit. Your spirit is the part of you where the entrance of His Word brings light. Mark 4 says, "Is a candle lit to be hidden under a bushel?" What is the Word of God given to you for? Is it not to understand? It is to sit on a tabletop so everyone who walks into the room can walk by the light of it.

If God has my spirit, then the Holy Spirit has the part of me where the light of the body becomes the eye. He has the part of me where the entrance of His Word brings light. He has the part of me He illuminates with faith.

It is not my money He wants. You cannot serve God and money. You will hate one, cleave to the other, hold to one, and despise the other.

Luke 16:19 says:

There was a certain rich man,
which was clothed in purple and fine linen,
and fared sumptuously every day:
And there was a certain beggar named Lazarus,
which was laid at his gate,
full of sores,
And desiring to be fed with the crumbs
which fell from the rich man's table:
moreover the dogs came and licked his sores.

If we are going to study the deceitfulness of riches, it helps to study somebody who had money.

This rich man lived royally. He fared sumptuously every day. Lazarus was laid at his gate full of sores, and the dogs came and licked his sores.

And it came to pass,
that the beggar died,
and was carried by the angels into Abraham's bosom:
the rich man also died,
and was buried;
And in hell he lift up his eyes,
being in torments,
and seeth Abraham afar off,
and Lazarus in his bosom.
And he cried and said,
Father Abraham,
have mercy on me,
and send Lazarus,
that he may dip the tip of his finger in water,
and cool my tongue;
for I am tormented in this flame.

Abraham said:

Son,
remember that thou in thy lifetime receivedst thy good things,
and likewise Lazarus evil things:
but now he is comforted,
and thou art tormented.
And beside all this,
between us and you there is a great gulf fixed.

When the rich man saw that he could not get relief from his torment, he switched his begging:

I pray thee therefore, father,
that thou wouldest send him to my father's house:
For I have five brethren;
that he may testify unto them,
lest they also come into this place of torment.

The only reason he was begging Abraham to send Lazarus to his five brothers was because they were living in the same gross violation of the Abrahamic covenant as the rich man had when he ended up in hell. He knew it.

Abraham answered:

They have Moses and the prophets;
let them hear them.

The rich man said:

Nay, father Abraham:
but if one went unto them from the dead,
they will repent.

Abraham said:

If they hear not Moses and the prophets,
neither will they be persuaded,
though one rose from the dead.

Hang on to that. He is telling me there is only one power on the face of this earth that carries enough wallop to change your heart from riches to a servant's heart, and that is the Word of God.

He said, "Your five brothers have the same thing you had. They have Moses and the prophets. Let them hear them." Moses represented the law, and the prophets represented the voice of the Holy Spirit.

We have the same thing. We have the Word of God. I am testifying to you. He is transforming me and changing me day by day into His image as I pray in the Holy Ghost and get on my knees and say, "God, I do not just want to know Your Word. I want it to become part of me. More than that, I want to become part of it. My God, give me a servant's heart."

If they will not hear the Word, neither will they be persuaded though a man came back from the dead and said, "Straighten your act up."

I am leaving nothing to chance. I do not trust the filthy stuff.

"Do you have any?"

Of course I have it, because it does not have me.

Back in Luke 16:13, Jesus warned about the power of money:

No servant can serve two masters:
for either he will hate the one,
and love the other;
or else he will hold to the one,
and despise the other.
Ye cannot serve God and mammon.

Mammon means riches pertaining to mankind in this temporary existence.

When I became an ultimate servant to God and God alone, and believe me, that is a bigger bite than some of you think, money began to serve me. In proportion to how I serve the kingdom, He made money serve me.

Money is nothing more than a natural expression from the spiritual world of faith. It does not replace faith. Any time you start looking at money as your source instead of the fruit of your faith, you are already in trouble.

When I believed God out of that first old car, that 1958 Chevrolet with 160,000 miles on it when the speedometer broke, and out of that old house in the poor part of town where it did no good to pull the curtains because they could see you through the wall, I was thirty years old.

I was the picture of success, pulling boards off a chain and stacking them in a neat row so a forklift could pick them up, so houses could be built where they do not have trees. That was my job. It took a lot of intellect: this board is sixteen feet, this one is twelve, this one goes in the eight-foot stack. My God, I was at full potential.

One day I woke up and realized Somebody greater than I could even imagine lived on the inside of me, and I had access to the mind of Christ. I was so hungry inside.

About that time, after I quit my job, somebody delivered me an old box of Kenneth Hagin reel-to-reel tapes from the days when he preached three hours a session. Those tapes convinced me I was the righteousness of God in faith, instead of a pile of filthy unrighteous rags crawling through life toward a cabin in the corner of glory land, barely making it by the skin of my teeth.

They convinced me I was righteous, and that Jesus bore my poverty. I believed my way out of that old car, out of that old house, into a new car, a van, a motor home, another house, a print shop, and a television studio. Most of that came within twelve months from the day I got my first Hagin tape.

I went all over Oregon preaching, "You do not have to be poor anymore, because Jesus has borne your poverty." Immediately, being a young ministry, they labeled me as one of those prosperity teachers, published my name on a list, and sent it all over Oregon. It did not hurt me much because nobody was letting me preach for them anyway.

I would rent halls for five dollars, fast and pray in tongues around the clock, listen to a Hagin tape thirty-five times, then walk out and find five people in an American Legion hall who came because of a little paper ad. I would tell them the whole tape, then pray for them.

Miracles started to flow. I had prayed and fasted so much that things began to happen even though I did not have much to say.

I went to hold a revival for a preacher in The Dalles, Oregon. A man hitchhiked in the night I started the meeting and stayed at the pastor's house where I was staying. I was trying to eat a bowl of oatmeal, and I can still remember it because his eyes were boring a hole right here like a laser beam.

Pretty soon he said, "Tell me something. What about your get-rich-quick schemes, fleecing the sheep?"

My blood boiled. Sanctification was further removed than it is now. I got so mad I could not see straight.

The Lord kept trying to get through to me: "Roberson, calm down. If you will calm down, I will tell you what to say."

I watched the man's mouth moving, heard his voice trail off, and went off into the Spirit, listening to God. When I came back, he was saying, "I have my pack sack and my bedroll. I hitchhike up and down Interstate 5, witnessing to the people who pick me up. Do you think I need all this stuff you guys have?"

I said, "Okay, Lord, You told me You would give me what to say."

He said, "Call him selfish."

I said, "Sir, you are selfish."

He said, "What? I am selfish?"

"Yes, you are selfish."

Then the Lord gave me a verse:

No servant can serve two masters:
for either he will hate the one,
and love the other;
or else he will hold to the one,
and despise the other.
Ye cannot serve God and mammon.

I heard myself saying things far too wise for my intellect, so I suspected they came from God.

I said, "Sir, I suppose you think I and the other guys trample people and use people in the race after the almighty powerful dollar."

He said, "As a matter of fact..."

I said, "Let me tell you something. There are two ways you can serve money. In light of the fact that He delivered to you one talent, two, or three, and told them to invest, you are filling the role of the one who buried his talent. Upon the Lord's return, he had nothing to show for it."

I said, "Jesus has borne our poverty, and it has been recorded in the annals of heaven that while Dave Roberson walked this earth, He made everything heaven had available to me. By the grace of God, He became poor so that through the substitution of Himself in my poverty, I might take His place. Whether I ever use one penny of it for the gospel or not, the exchange was still made."

"Sir, you have the potential to meet thousands of people's needs, but you buried it. Poverty has become your master, and it is dictating to you what you will or will not do for the kingdom. Sir, you are serving the filthy stuff."

That shut him up.

I gave a parable, and a woman cried out in a loud voice, "Oh my God!" I had to stop in the middle and laugh.

I told about my nine-year-old boy running up to me:

"Daddy, can I have a BB gun?"

Now I did not grab him by the shirt, slap him unconscious, put on steel-toed boots, kick him for thirty minutes, throw him into a cement wall, wait two days for him to regain consciousness, jerk him up again, and say, "Son, when are you going to become an asset instead of a liability in this family?"

I bought him the BB gun.

You should have seen him two days later. "Dad, I just missed the tree." He shot out the neighbor's four-hundred-dollar insulated plate-glass window.

I could have bought him a Corvette, and he would have ransacked the Corvette to find the BB gun, because Corvettes were not where that little flesh creature was. He wanted his BB gun.

That is the way many of us are when we find out God has delivered us from poverty. The spiritual aspects are not as important as the physical. As little flesh creatures, we grab our Father by the leg and say, "Can I have a new car? How about a motor home? Would it be too much to ask for one for my wife? How about a house?"

After a while, you can only drive one car at a time. You can only live in one house. I almost had to hire an accountant to keep up with all the stuff. I got tired of it and started giving things away.

God had faith in me. He knew I would wake up one day to:

Seek ye first the kingdom of God,
and his righteousness;
and all these things shall be added unto you.

He knew the same faith this little flesh creature used on things would one day take entire cities for the gospel.

He has faith in you too. He does not care if you have toys. He cares if you never get past the deceitfulness of riches. If you never get past it, you will never experience that kind of faith and that kind of joy, knowing your need is met no matter what happens.

For the Lord God shall you serve, and Him alone.

Luke 17:1 says:

It is impossible but that offences will come:
but woe unto him,
through whom they come!
It were better for him
that a millstone were hanged about his neck,
and he cast into the sea,
than that he should offend one of these little ones.

Even over the impossibility of a man rising from the dead, Jesus said offenses will still come. Men will still go on offending over money because of the power in it.

I have been to Jerusalem and seen plenty of millstones. The one place I do not want to be is out for an afternoon swim with a two-ton millstone chained around my neck. Believe me, it is much easier to quit offending over the filthy stuff.

What do you want it for? What is the standard for your prosperity? Why does that company exist anyway? What are your priorities? Who is the senior partner?

You ought to see Jesus make money. But it depends what you want Him to make it for. There is nothing else on His mind.

"I have the mind of Christ."

Not if it does not think like that.

Jesus continues:

Take heed to yourselves:
If thy brother trespass against thee,
rebuke him;
and if he repent,
forgive him.
And if he trespass against thee seven times in a day,
and seven times in a day turn again to thee,
saying,
I repent;
thou shalt forgive him.

Matthew says seventy times seven, 490 times. Let me tell you who God is protecting. It is you.

Can you imagine somebody taking you for a ride 490 times in one day over your money, then turning again and saying, "I repent," and you saying, "That is okay"? Not hardly.

That is the way Peter thought too. I know it was Peter in the next verse:

And the apostles said unto the Lord,
Increase our faith.

Did Peter say that when Jesus walked across the water? Did he say it when Jesus raised Lazarus from the dead? If it had been me, I would have stapled myself to Jesus' robe and let Him drag me around until I could do that.

After the five thousand and their families were fed with two fish and five loaves, did any of them pipe up and say, "My God, increase our faith"?

No. But when Jesus talked about the two masters, the rich man who lived in gross violation of the Abrahamic covenant and would not even give Lazarus crumbs, and then talked about forgiving your brother over money up to 490 times a day, Peter said, "My God, Man, increase our faith."

Jesus answered:

If ye had faith as a grain of mustard seed,
ye might say unto this sycamine tree,
Be thou plucked up by the root,
and be thou planted in the sea;
and it should obey you.

Then He says:

But which of you,
having a servant plowing or feeding cattle,
will say unto him by and by,
when he is come from the field,
Go and sit down to meat?
And will not rather say unto him,
Make ready wherewith I may sup,
and gird thyself,
and serve me,
till I have eaten and drunken;
and afterward thou shalt eat and drink?
Doth he thank that servant because he did the things that were commanded him?
I trow not.

They knew what servants were. Peter had a fishing franchise. Matthew was a tax collector. Luke was a physician. They understood servants.

Jesus said a servant makes sure all the needs of his master are met first, then he eats off the master's table. Then Jesus said:

So likewise ye,
when ye shall have done all those things which are commanded you,
say,
We are unprofitable servants:
we have done that which was our duty to do.

You want an increase of faith? You want to move the tree into the ocean? You want stewardship and prosperity? What do you want it for?

Do you want that increase of faith to serve the kingdom of God as a servant, making sure the needs of the kingdom are met first by seeking first His righteousness? Or do you want to set up a kingdom here to serve the lusts of your flesh?

Has the deceitfulness of riches deceived you, or has poverty dominated you so you cannot even trust God? What is the extent of your vision: "Meet my need and let the rest of the world go to hell"?

What do you want it for?

There is only one way the increase will come: if you have a servant's heart.

The deceitfulness of riches entering in chokes the productiveness of the Word of God, and it becomes unfruitful.